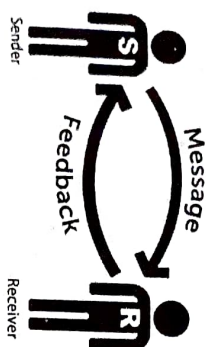


UNIT 1 Theory and Types of Communication

Communication is a two-way process by which a sender and receiver exchange ideas and information. The sender encodes a message and sends it to the receiver. The receiver receives the message, interprets it and responds to it. Thus, one cycle in the process of communication is completed.



Task 1

Read the following conversation and answer the questions that follow.

Bishwajit: Good morning Sir!

Manager: Morning, Nareesh! You look worried. Is something the matter?

Bishwajit: Err ... Yes, Sir, my laptop has been giving me problems despite getting it repaired several times. Because of this, I am unable to work without interruption.

Manager: Oh ... I see. You mean to say you need more time to complete your work?

Bishwajit: Not really, Sir ... Err ... I meant ... Oh ... never mind, Sir.

Manager: Okay then ... let's get back to work.

1. What do you think Bishwajit was trying to tell his Manager?
.....
2. Why is Bishwajit unsuccessful in conveying his message?
.....
3. If you were in Bishwajit's place how would you convey the same message?
.....

In the above conversation, the message is conveyed in simple words and yet does not seem to reach the receiver in the intended manner. We can see that hesitation on the part of the subordinate to express his need for a new laptop clearly affects the communication adversely. A better choice of words and phrasing would have led to a different outcome.

In the conversation above, the message is verbal. However, that may not always be the case. Even a picture or a graphic can be used to convey messages. For example, traffic signals are universally understood symbols. When a signal turns red, all vehicles stop. When it turns green they start again. Likewise, a graphic of 'skull and crossbones' is universally understood to be a sign of danger. These symbols are unambiguous and can convey the intended message effectively to even people who cannot read a language. However, communication is not always that simple. Structured communication requires greater effort from both the sender and receiver.

Let us now understand the basics of how communication takes place and how it can be made more effective.

The communication cycle

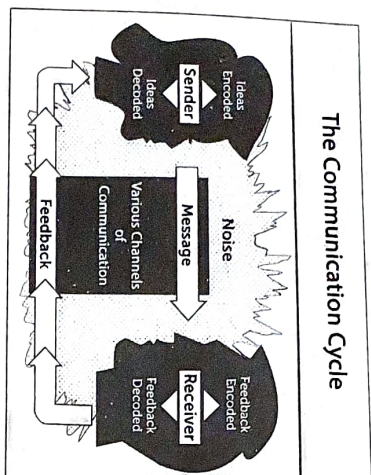
Imagine that two people are engaged in conversation with each other. Communication starts the moment the first few words are uttered by one of them. The sender has sent across a message to the listener. If the listener responds to the message appropriately, it means that the speaker has encoded the message properly and the receiver has decoded it easily.

When we encode a message, we use language as a medium. The medium must be chosen carefully to ensure that the message reaches the listener with least distortion. When the receiver responds to the message, he/she becomes the sender of the message and the speaker becomes the receiver. The message that the receiver sends back is the feedback.

Sometimes, the message sent to the receiver comes to him either in a distorted form or does not reach him at all. This may happen because of some disturbance in the channel used to transmit the message. For example, if there is a lot of background noise or when the speaker is speaking from considerable distance, the listener may not be able to hear him/her well. This disturbance in the channel of communication, known as 'noise', can adversely affect the quality of communication. Noise in the channel needs to be controlled for effective communication. Also, the channel and medium of communication should be carefully selected on the basis of the attributes of the sender and receiver and the context in which the communication is taking place.

Look at the graphic overleaf that denotes the process of communication. Note the various channels of communication that are available at a typical modern workplace.

The Communication Cycle



As we can see from this graphic, communication is a cyclical process involving the following:

- sender
- receiver
- message
- medium
- channel
- feedback
- noise

Task 2

Match the terms in column A to their meanings in column B.

Column A	Column B
feedback	a system of signals and rules containing meaning that is comprehensible to both sender and receiver
noise	forming a message using a set of gestures, symbols or words
medium	the information encoded by the sender
decoding	reaction to a message or a piece of communicative text
context	the process of comprehension
message	an external factor which interrupts the transmission of the message
encoding	the situation within which communication happens

Stages in the process of communication

Let us now look at the various stages in the process of communication.

Stage 1: Encoding the message

The first stage of communication involves the creation of a message. For this, the speaker has to take into account *who* he/she wants to send his message to and what he/she wants to communicate. According to the profile of the receiver and the context, the sender must decide on the appropriate language/level of language to be used in communication. In certain situations, the medium might be a graphic – say a sign or a visual on a poster.

Stage 2: Transmission of the message

The second stage is the transmission of the message through an appropriate channel. Depending on who the receiver is and the content of the message, the sender must decide on the channel of communication: oral or written. For example, it is good to send business messages to colleagues or persons of a high seniority level in an organisation in written form. Similarly, long and complex messages should be sent in written form. In the written form, messages can be sent as emails, memos, circulars, notices etc. In the oral form, they can be face-to-face, telephonic conversations or announcements over a public-address system.

Stage 3: Reception of the message

After the message is transmitted by the sender, the receiver receives it. The reception of the message may involve listening, viewing or reading at the receiver's end.

Step 4: Decoding the message

Decoding is the receiver's interpretation of the received message. Here the receiver converts the message into thoughts and tries to analyse and understand it. Effective communication occurs only when both the sender and the receiver assign the same or similar meanings to the message.

Step 5: Giving feedback/response

After decoding the message, the receiver gives his feedback to the sender either in spoken or written form or in the form of a gesture. The sender is thus reassured of the fact that the message is understood correctly. This completes the communication cycle.

For successful communication, one needs to keep in mind the following points:

- The message must be clear, brief and appropriate to the context.
- Unnecessary information must be filtered out.
- The medium of communication must be mutually intelligible to both parties.
- The channel of communication must be appropriate to the context.
- The information given must be complete and error free.
- Communication must take into account intercultural norms.
- The feedback should be appropriate.
- The sender should be conscious of tone and pitch of voice as well as choice of words.

Task 3

Read the following conversations and identify the reason for miscommunication.

Conversation 1

Amit: Pradip, I need the folder with the contract documents for tomorrow's General Body meeting.

Pradip: Okay, Sir. I will mail it to you.

Amit: Mail it? But why? I'm right here!

Pradip: Eh! I!

Conversation 2

American tourist (to an attendant at a petrol bunk in England): Can you fill the gas please?

Attendant: Sorry, Sir. We fill only petrol.

Tourist: That's what I meant!

Attendant: Eh?

Formal and informal communication

Task 4

Read the following pieces of conversation.

1. A: Hi Prabal! What are you doing in this week-long autumn break?

B: Hi Abhimanyu! I'm not sure. What about you?

A: I'm thinking of going to the Regional Science Centre here in Guwahati. They are holding a three-day science exhibition and conference there. Come along. It'll be a great experience.

B: Yeah! That's a cool idea. It will be of great help in my third-year college project as well.

2. A: Good morning Mr Ghosh!

B: Good morning Mr Basu! Have we spoken with the bank for a loan for the construction of the new apartment block?

A: Yes. But unfortunately, the loan hasn't been sanctioned.

B: That's a big problem. Shall we meet and discuss this in the afternoon at 2.30 today?

A: Yes, sure. I'll come over.

How are the two conversations different?

Formal communication

The above two conversations show two different levels of formality in communication. When we talk to our friends and family we use informal language and a casual tone. Our discussion also revolves around informal topics. On the other hand, our conversations with those in authority like teachers, principals, seniors or colleagues at work are formal, precise and structured. In such formal contexts, we engage in conversation on matters related to academics or business such as seeking permission, making requests, giving or seeking information, persuading others for something, thanking others etc. In all these instances, what we say and how we say it are usually definite and pre-determined.

Our conversations with people we are meeting for the first time are generally marked by a hint of formality wherein we greet and introduce ourselves, talk minimally and refrain from being casual in language or tone. Once we get to know the person our conversation with them may take on a more familiar and casual tone. So formality of communication depends on both the context and the level of familiarity between the interlocutors.

Informal communication is largely oral. Although it can also be in the written form sometimes. For example: exchange of SMS, text or emails over mobile phones. Formal communication can happen in oral or written form.

Oral – business meetings, official telephonic conversations, interviews etc.

Written – emails, letters, memos, office orders, circulars etc.

Let us look at the advantages and disadvantages of formal communication.

Advantages:

- Formal communication helps establish healthy relations between the interlocutors.
- If done through a proper channel, it helps in clear and effective communication among employees at different levels.

- Since formal communication is often documented, it is easy to retrieve and use for future purposes.
- Formal communication helps in maintaining discipline as it ensures that the employees are more careful with their work.

Disadvantages:

- It is time consuming, especially when there is a lot of information to be sent.
- It may lead to misinterpretation of information, especially when it happens orally. A message may get distorted as it travels down to people at various levels in an organisation.
- Sometimes, stiff formal conversations lead to an authoritarian culture within organisations which might be detrimental to healthy collaboration and team work.

Informal communication

Informal communication is the opposite of formal communication. It refers to a casual form of talk with our friends and family. Unlike formal communication wherein what we speak is structured and predetermined, informal communication is characterised by the use of spontaneous speech. While speaking informally, we adopt a casual tone and behaviour and use language in a rather carefree manner. Informal communication allows us to address our friends using their first names or nicknames and greet them with an informal 'hi' or 'hello'. We encounter informal situations during community meals, parties and get-togethers and other social events. Informal communication, like formal communication, has its own advantages and disadvantages.

Advantages:

- Informal communication is often an unofficial channel for the flow of information. It is not limited by rules pertaining to structure and content. Depending on the situation, one may talk about anything informally.
- It is not a top-down communication; it discourages authoritarian attitudes and encourages friendly communication.
- It is flexible in nature and free from all formalities.

Disadvantages:

- Since informal communication happens in oral form, there is no written record for future reference.
- It is also free from any accountability.
- Information received through informal channels is not always reliable. There is also a risk of distortion of message.

Oral communication

Oral communication refers to communication by way of speech. It is the fastest means of communication. Examples of such communication include face-to-face or telephonic conversation. Oral communication can be both formal and informal. Interviews, business meetings, telephonic conversations for official purposes et cetera are examples of formal conversations. Get-togethers, parties, telephonic conversation between friends and relatives et cetera are examples of informal communication.

Written communication

Written communication refers to communication by means of writing. It is a powerful medium of communication in professional and business settings. Examples of written communication include business letters, emails, fax messages, memos, notices, circulars, agendas, minutes and reports. Written communication is used in professional setups for laying down rules, making notes, sending official orders, lodging complaints etc. Written documents can be referred to repeatedly in future and circulated among many people.

Visual communication

Visual communication refers to communication by means of visuals such as charts, pictures, graphs, signs and symbols. As compared to words, visuals help us communicate messages more effectively by drawing the attention of the audience. They are hence time-saving and can be used to communicate with those audiences as well who cannot read. However, visuals should be carefully chosen such that they are understood even in cross-cultural situations. Visuals can enhance the effect of the message communicated and ensure better recall. Some examples of visual communication that we come across on a day-to-day basis are traffic signs, maps, posters, pie-charts, bar-graphs etc.

Audio-visual communication

In some cases, communication happens both visually and aurally, for example, in advertisements, television programmes, films, video conferences etc. Such a form of communication is extremely powerful and attractive and can reach a wide range of audiences. Audio-visual communication ensures retention of the message and has the potential to have a great impact on people. For this reason, it can be used to tell stories, sell ideas and to connect with people. However, it is an expensive means of communication and often requires professional knowledge of video and sound editing.

Non-verbal communication

Unlike verbal communication, non-verbal communication does not make use of words to communicate messages. In non-verbal communication the sender communicates through body language, facial expressions and paralinguistic elements such as intonation and pitch. We send non-verbal messages to others all the time. For example, the way we sit, stand or walk communicates a lot about us. If, while talking to someone, we sit in a position inclined towards the person we are talking to, it may indicate our interest in speaking to him/her. However, if we face away, it may show that we are not interested. We will learn in detail about non-verbal communication in the next chapter.

UNIT 2 Verbal and Non-Verbal Communication

Verbal communication includes any form of communication which makes use of sounds, words and language in spoken form. Verbal communication enables us to define the world around us, express ideas, experiences and emotions. However, verbal communication does not exist in isolation from non-verbal communication. Especially oral communication is often accompanied by body language. When we speak we also use gestures, postures of the body, facial expressions, eye contact, touch et cetera to communicate. In most situations we use a combination of verbal and non-verbal language to convey messages.

Verbal messages are often easy to understand and interpret. Non-verbal communication, on the other hand, relies on subtle facial expressions, gestures, postures et cetera and can be more complex and difficult to interpret. An understanding of non-verbal communication can help us become better communicators. For example, a person may be inwardly seething about a situation but may maintain a calm exterior particularly in a professional setup. His speech may be calm and composed but his gestures give away the true state of his mind. Watch out for symptoms like a clenched fist or a nervous tick on his forehead which convey his latent anger.

Task 1

Look at the following pictures and guess the emotions they portray.



a.



b.



c.



d.

Task 2

List a few typical gestures or facial expressions that portray the four emotions shown in Task 1.

-
-
-
-

Functions of non-verbal communication

An understanding of non-verbal communication can give us an upper hand in interviews and business dealings. Based on the non-verbal cues we receive from others, we can predict their reactions and alter the communication strategy to our benefit. For instance, while you are negotiating a deal with someone, if you are able to read the subtle signals conveyed through his/her posture, gestures and facial expression, you will have an upper hand in the deal. If you can read the subtle signals a colleague or classmate is using to convey that he/she is unhappy with a situation at work or in class, you can take corrective action to prevent the situation from deteriorating further.

Overall non-verbal communication has the following functions. It:

- expresses attitudes, feelings and emotions
- develops interpersonal relationships
- supports verbal interaction
- reflects an individual's personality
- performs routine interactive functions such as greetings and goodbyes
- detects falsehood

Differences between verbal and non-verbal communication

Let us now understand the difference between verbal and non-verbal communication.

Verbal communication	Non-verbal communication
1. Involves a system of communication that is structured using proper rules of grammar; the structure helps in understanding messages clearly	Not structured and therefore, interpreted according to the cultural and situational context

Verbal communication	Non-verbal communication
2. Has a well-defined starting and ending point	Goes on continuously, even when the person has stopped speaking; for example, stares or frowns often persist after a heated argument
3. Little chance of miscommunication as each word in a language has a distinct contextual meaning	As meanings of non-verbal messages vary based on cultural context, there are chances of miscommunication.
4. Does not require the physical presence of the person; it can happen from a distance – over telephone or through written emails, letters, chat etc.	Happens in most cases when the person is physically present; an exception would be the use of various paralinguistic elements like pitch and tone of voice when a person is communicating telephonically
5. Easier to document and present as evidence in court	Difficult to document and register as evidence
6. Usually voluntary – we can think before we speak	Often involuntary and, hence, difficult to conceal

Interaction of the verbal and the non-verbal modes of communication

As stated earlier, non-verbal communication does not happen in isolation. It interacts with verbal communication in the following ways:

1. **Reinforces:** Non-verbal messages can reinforce verbal messages which means they can strengthen and support them. For example, a wave of the hand accompanying a spoken 'goodbye' reinforces the message.
2. **Substitutes:** Non-verbal communication can at times substitute verbal communication. For example, a finger on one's lips can be used to indicate the need for silence.
3. **Contradicts:** Non-verbal communication contradicts verbal communication when they both signify different things. A sideways shaking of the head while saying 'yes' instead of a nod is practiced in some cultures and found confusing by others.
4. **Complements:** Sometimes, non-verbal messages complete the meaning of the verbal message. Lowering the head and using a sombre tone when speaking about sad things makes the message more sincere.
5. **Emphasises:** Non-verbal communication can be used to emphasise what one says verbally.

We often use hand gestures or pauses in speech to emphasise an important point.

6. **Regulates:** Non-verbal means of communication can be used to regulate or control verbal communication. You may look at your watch to indicate to someone that they should stop talking as you are running out of time.

Forms of non-verbal communication

As we have already seen, there are many ways in which we communicate non-verbally – through gestures, facial expressions, postures, tone of voice etc. Let us study the various forms in which non-verbal communication takes place.

Kinesics

Kinesics comes from the root word 'kinesis' which means 'movement'. Hence, it is the study of facial expressions, eye movement and gaze, gestures and postures. Let us look at the possible meanings of some non-verbal signals.

(i) Facial expressions

The face is the most expressive means of communicating non-verbally. Examples:

- Smile: personality traits such as friendliness and confidence
- Raising of eyebrows: doubt or disbelief
- Knotted brows: annoyance or deep thought
- Frown: sadness
- Smirking lips: sarcasm
- Widened eyes and gaping mouth: surprise

(ii) Eye movement and eye contact (Oculistics)

Oculistics is the study of eye behaviour such eye movement, gaze, eye contact etc.

Examples:

- Avoiding eye contact: (in some Asian cultures) considered a mark of respect; in other contexts, such as in interviews, signals lack of confidence
- A shifty-eyed look: lack of trustworthiness
- A glazed look: lack of concentration on the on-going activity
- Glaring: suggestive of intimidation

(iii) Gestures

Gestures are a form of non-verbal communication used to make speech more expressive. We gesture using various parts of our body such as hands, head, shoulders etc. Here are some typical gestures with their possible meanings:

- Hands in pocket: over-confident, casual attitude
- Arms tightly folded across one's chest: not open to ideas and suggestions
- Clenching of hands: frustration
- Rubbing hands: quick movements indicate excitement, whereas slow movements indicate fear or anxiety
- Scratching the head: confusion
- Stroking one's chin: giving a serious thought to something

However, it pays to remember that gestures should not be read in isolation. They should be studied in clusters. For example, a person may cross his arm tightly across his chest when he is feeling cold. It might not be a sign of his close mindedness. Additionally, study the expression on his face to determine if he is indeed not being open to ideas.

(iv) Posture

Posture refers to the body position of an individual. Posture can be suggestive of various things such as the power relationship between the two individuals communicating, the attitude of a person towards others etc. Here are some pointers for a desirable posture:

- While standing, one should stand with feet fixed firmly on the floor, and the spine should be straight, but not too straight, too loose or too rigid.
- Avoid bending forward while standing.
- While sitting, one must have the shoulders straight, spine fairly straight and head upright.
- Sit comfortably. Avoid sitting at the edge of the chair or leaning too far back in it. Avoid rocking the chair or shaking one's feet.
- Sit with legs comfortably apart, resting on the ground. Do not sit with legs crossed casually or with the ankle placed over the other knee when in formal situations.

Haptics

The word 'haptics' pertains to the sense of touch. Touch can signify warmth, friendship, love, intimacy, anger, disinterest or sexual feelings. It can be used to accomplish social functions such as a handshake when we meet someone; it can be used as a supportive gesture such as keeping a hand on someone's shoulder; it can be functional such as lending a hand to help someone climb the stairs; or it can be regulative such as touching someone's arm to signal that

they stop talking or to signal that you want to talk. Here are some types of handshakes with the attitude they convey:

- A limp or partial handshake: lack of self-confidence
- An extremely tight handshake: superiority complex
- A perspiring hand: nervousness
- An equal handshake: confidence and interest

Proxemics

Proxemics deals with the amount of space that people feel it necessary and appropriate to set between themselves as interlocutors. Space has cultural, behavioural and sociological meaning and relevance. Space is divided into four categories depending on the situation and people involved.

- Intimate space (less than 1.5 feet): an extremely close relationship (used for close encounters such as embracing, touching or whispering)
- Personal space (1.5–4 feet): a close relationship
- Social space (4–12 feet): space between the persons talking during business dealings or interacting at social occasions
- Public space (more than 12 feet): space between the speaker and the audience during public speeches and lectures

Vocalics or paralanguage

Vocalics deals with the study of paralinguistic or non-lexical component of communication. Under vocalics, we study the pitch, rate, intonation and volume of speech and the voice markers signalling hesitation. Voice interacts with the verbal message in a variety of ways. For example, we may raise the volume of our voice to emphasise what we are saying. We may lower the voice to suggest the end of our turn so that the other person can take it as a cue to start speaking. In this sense, voice is regulative as it controls the speech turns. Voice can even contradict or weaken the impact of the verbally uttered 'congratulations' if the intonation is not proper. Here are a few things to watch out for when speaking:

- Your voice should be evenly pitched. A high-pitched voice shows nervousness and a low-pitched voice shows that the spoken matter is confidential.
- The speed of talking must be moderate. A high speed indicates over enthusiasm and a low speed indicates one is not well prepared to speak.
- The speech should be marked by appropriate variations in tone. Lack of tonal variations makes the speech dull and monotonous.
- Stressing on words and at appropriate places in the sentences, provides clarity of meaning.

Task 3

In what way does non-verbal language interact with verbal language in these situations? Pick answers from the box.

substitutes

regulates

contradicts

complements

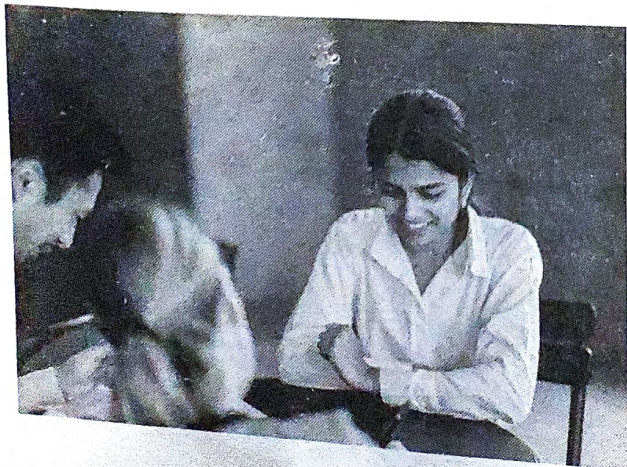
reinforces

1. Aruna points towards the door while asking her subordinate to leave.
2. Abhoy indicates the end of his speech with the use of falling tone indicating that someone else can begin speaking if he/she wants to.
3. A child refuses to meet her mother's eye while telling her, 'I have not broken the glass vase.'
.....
4. When the father asked his daughter whether she wanted more chocolates, she nodded her head.
5. On being asked the way to a hotel by someone who understands little English, Binoba points towards the left with his finger as he says 'left'.

Culture and non-verbal communication

Most forms of verbal and non-verbal communication are usually learned and not innate. Exceptions are non-verbal behaviours like crying, groaning in pain et cetera, which are innate and universal. Many non-verbal cues are arbitrary and vary from culture to culture. For example, a nod might mean *yes* in one culture and *no* in another. Therefore, the cultural context plays an important role in the interpretation of non-verbal language. In a multi-cultural work environment, it pays to be conscious of these differences. Let us look at two examples:

1. In many Asian cultures, avoiding eye contact, particularly with elders or those in authority is considered a sign of respect. Whereas in American culture eye contact is an important aspect of communication.



2. Crossing of arms across the chest is seen in many Asian cultures, including Indian, as a sign of deference and respect towards elders and persons in authority. The same gesture, with a slight change in stance and facial expression, can be seen in other cultures and contexts as a sign of defensiveness and lack of open-mindedness.

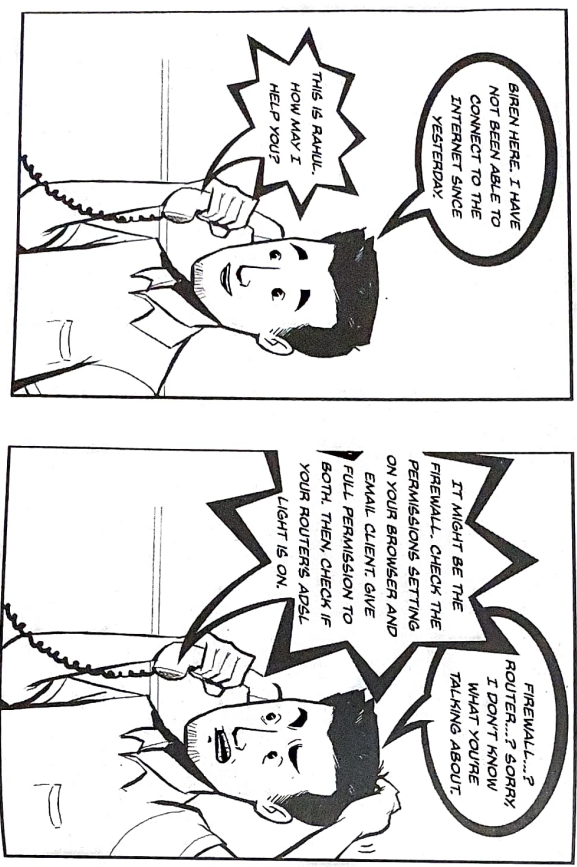


UNIT 3 Barriers and Strategies

We know that communication is a cyclical process which begins the moment we encode a message and send it to a receiver. The cycle is complete when the receiver receives the message, decodes it and sends feedback to the sender. Sometimes, there are hurdles in the free movement of a message between a sender and a receiver. These hurdles are known as barriers to communication. This chapter lists a few barriers that impede communication and suggests strategies to overcome them.

Task 1

The cartoon below shows a conversation between an employee of an organisation and a technical support engineer. Read the conversation and answer the following questions.



1. Do you think the above conversation is free of obstacles? If not, why?

Types of barriers to communication

Barriers to communication can be of several types – they may be physical, psychological, cultural, linguistic, organisational, emotional or interpersonal in nature. Sometimes, prejudiced views and lack of sensitivity towards a group or community could also lead to improper communication. Let us look at some of these barriers in detail.

1. Physical barriers

Physical barriers to communication arise because of noise in the background, physical hindrances such as closed doors or physical distance between the two interlocutors. These barriers impede the message from reaching the listener. Sometimes, in case of telephonic conversation, faulty telephone lines or noise in the background may also cause obstacles in conversation. To overcome such barriers, one may do the following:

- Block out or alleviate the noise in the background. For example, switch off the TV or radio if it is causing the problem.
- If the listener is positioned far away, walk up to him/her or simply use the telephone. In office setups, the seating arrangement should be such that it facilitates easy conversation.

2. Linguistic barriers

Level and type of language was a barrier in the conversation we listened to under Task 1. The speaker wrongly presumed that the listener is familiar with technical terms and jargon in computer science. Linguistic barriers in communication may occur from the use of inappropriate medium of communication, misinterpretation, giving incomplete

2. Do you think the technical support engineer is making certain presumptions about the situation? If so, how do these presumptions affect communication?

information, ignoring spelling, grammar or punctuation, using redundant words etc. Let's look at a few strategies to overcome linguistic barriers:

- Keep your message concise and to the point.
- Move step-by-step. Do not say everything all at once.
- Keep the language of communication simple and free of difficult words.
- Use jargon only when you are sure that the listener understands it.
- Be cautious while choosing the medium of communication. It should be one that the listener speaks and comprehends. Similarly, be cautious while mixing languages.
- Make use of punctuation wherever necessary.

Task 2

Look at the following two pairs of sentences. Is there a difference in their meaning? What makes the difference?

1. (a) He eats shoots and leaves.
(b) He eats, shoots and leaves.
2. (a) Let's eat children.
(b) Let's eat, children.

3. Interpersonal barriers

The word 'interpersonal' pertains to relationships between people. Sometimes, communication barriers may arise because we do not listen properly or we do not reach out to others and speak with them openly without inhibition. At times, poor self-image or false presumptions and prejudices about others may also impede our communication with them. Here are a few strategies for overcoming interpersonal barriers:

- Inculcate the habit of listening attentively and proactively. It is frustrating for the speaker if the listener is not paying attention.
- Always listen to others before putting forward your point of view.
- Engage in communication with others more often. Do not hesitate to put forth your ideas.
- Keep emotions in control while communicating with people, particularly while negotiating. This will help us stay focussed on the goal of communication.
- Offer criticism that is constructive in nature. Criticism should help a person grow rather than demotivate or upset him/her.
- Be open to receiving feedback and suggestions from others. Do not allow these to hurt your ego.

Task 3

Identify the different strategies used for expressing criticism in the following situations.

1. Manager to Harideb, an intern at a hotel: 'I love how innovative you are with soups and salads. I really admire your skill. But, please don't mind me saying that the salt is at times slightly on the higher side.'

2. The client to Pronoy, a professional artist: 'I appreciate the abstract designs you paint on the canvases. But, if you don't mind me saying it, the colours used are sometimes very bright. Why don't you try painting with pastel colours?'

3. Manager to an interior designer at an architectural firm: 'I really liked the way you changed the interiors of the house. Your ideas are extremely innovative. But, the only challenge is that the space looks a little cluttered. I faced the same issue with my designs, until I started using wall mirrors to give the illusion of larger space.'

4. Professor to Sonjoy, a student researcher: 'Your research shows your clarity of subject and deep thought. But, can I give you a piece of advice? Always be careful while collecting data. The process of data collection should be free of prejudices.'

4. Prejudices and lack of sensitivity

Sometimes, our language contains thoughts and words that reflect a biased attitude towards a section of people. Such biases become evident in our conversation and can upset or offend people. Let us look at the following sentences:

- Here is the *chairman* of our company. (use *chairperson* instead)
- A special place has been reserved for the *handicapped* persons in the audience. (use *physically challenged* instead)
- This technology has been developed for the *blind*. (use *visually challenged* instead)

So, one must avoid using language that portrays our prejudices. Words and expressions that are likely to hurt people's sensibilities must be replaced with generic, gender neutral and socially acceptable words.